

Background

Honorifics (e.g., *Ms. Rachel*) plays a crucial role in social deixis by indexing hierarchical social relations and social distance.³ Far beyond alternate vocative forms, the Korean honorifics system manifests itself both lexically (e.g., 생일 vs. 생신 for *birthday*) and morpho-syntactically (e.g., verbal inflections; -요), forming a register (e.g., informal register to a friend; honorific register to a teacher).⁶

Past research brings to light the surprising usage of honorifics in child-directed speech (CDS).^{1,2} **The function of honorifics in CDS, however, remains unclear from case studies alone.**

Potential role of honorifics in CDS

We explore four potential roles of honorifics usage in CDS:

1. Honorifics solely indexes social distance.

The proportion of honorifics usage in CDS should mirror the proportion of honorifics usage to other family members of comparable social distance.

2. Honorifics is a general marker of linguistic input.

Honorifics usage should be directly proportional to the overall frequency of speech act categories.

3. Honorifics scaffolds behavioral socialization.

Utterances commending/discouraging behavior should be the most honorifics-marked.

4. Honorifics scaffolds linguistic socialization.

Utterances modeling honorifics usage should be the most honorifics-marked, i.e., in speech elicitations and roleplaying (e.g., as cashier and customer in a grocery store).

CHILDES Ko Corpus⁴



Naturalistic “home” recordings (audio only)

Age groups: 0;8, 1;1, 2;3 **Avg rec. duration** = 46.87 mins
N = 30 (10 per age group) (*SD* = 3.44; *range* = 16.22)

Speech act coding

Utterance-level speech act coding using Inventory of Communicative Acts - Abridged (**INCA-A**)⁵:

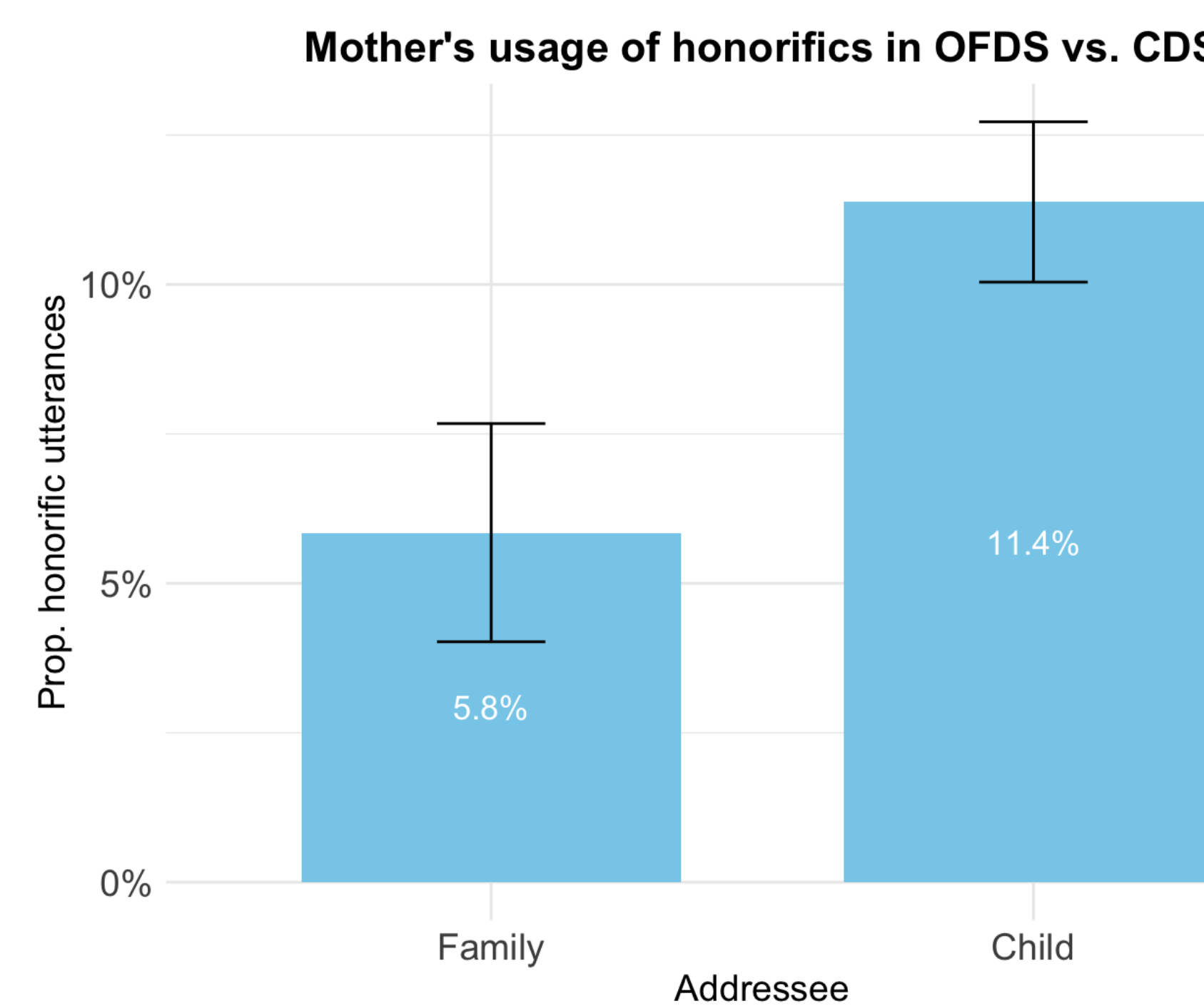
line_num	spkr	INCA-A	transcription
375	MOT	RQ	제일 큰 것부터 꺼 볼까요 그럼? most big-ATTR thing-from put.on try-SUPP.SUGQ-HON then Then shall we try on the biggest one first?
380	CHI	ST	엄마 안 돼. mom not allowed We can't Mom.
384	MOT	YQ	안 돼요? not allowed-HON We can't?
389	MOT	ST	할 수 있어요. do-FUT.ATTR ability exist-HON We can.

CDS metadata

age group	mean utts/min	SD	mean num unique speech acts	SD
0;8	38.3	9.4	29.9	4.60
1;1	39.6	5.7	33.4	3.87
2;3	39.1	3.2	38.5	3.14

Honorifics in CDS is *dynamic*, not static

More than a marker of social distance



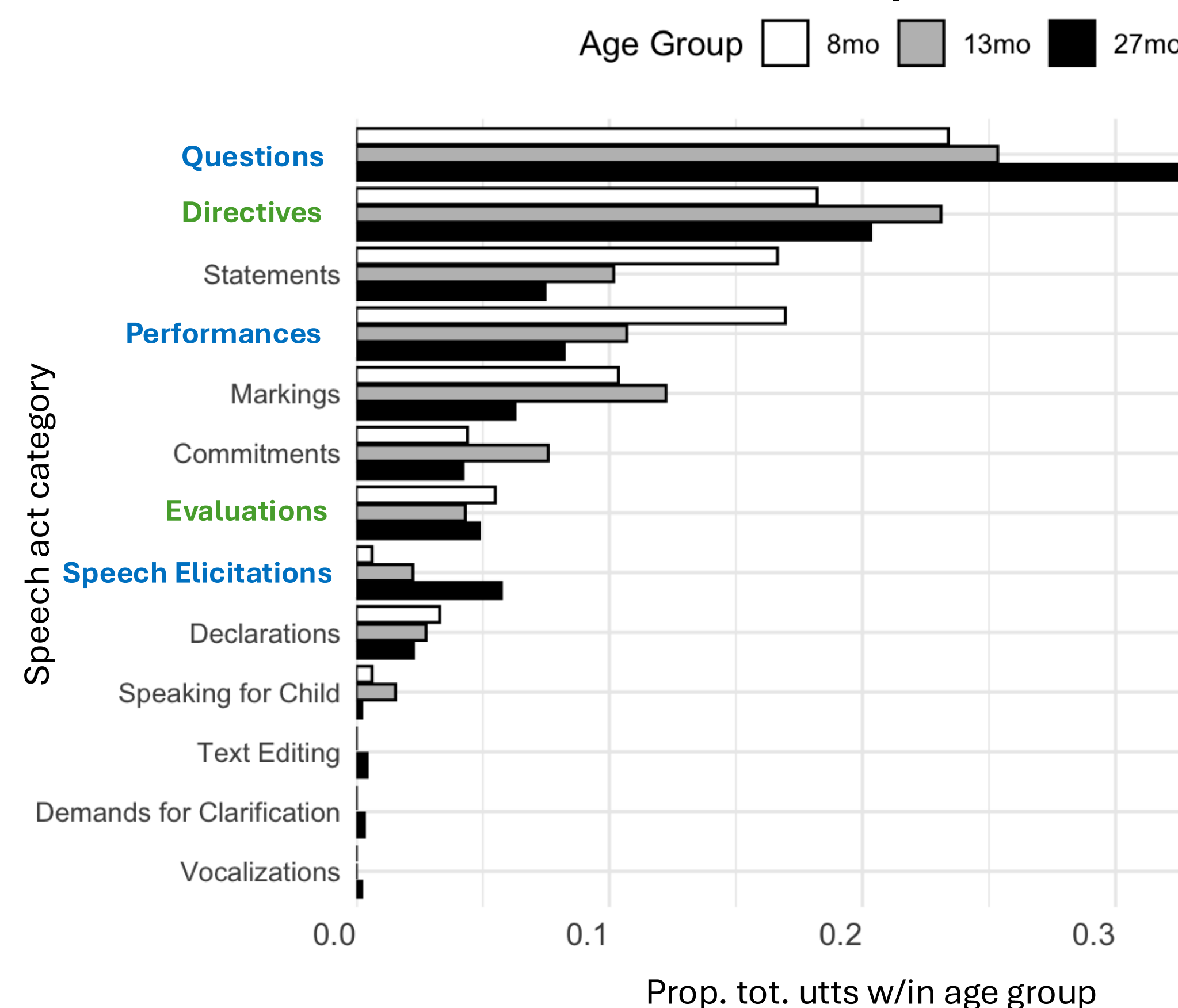
Honorifics were used significantly more in CDS than in Other-Family-Directed-Speech (OFDS). ($t(28) = 3.16, p < 0.005$ adult baseline prop. = 78.6%)

More than a general marker of linguistic input

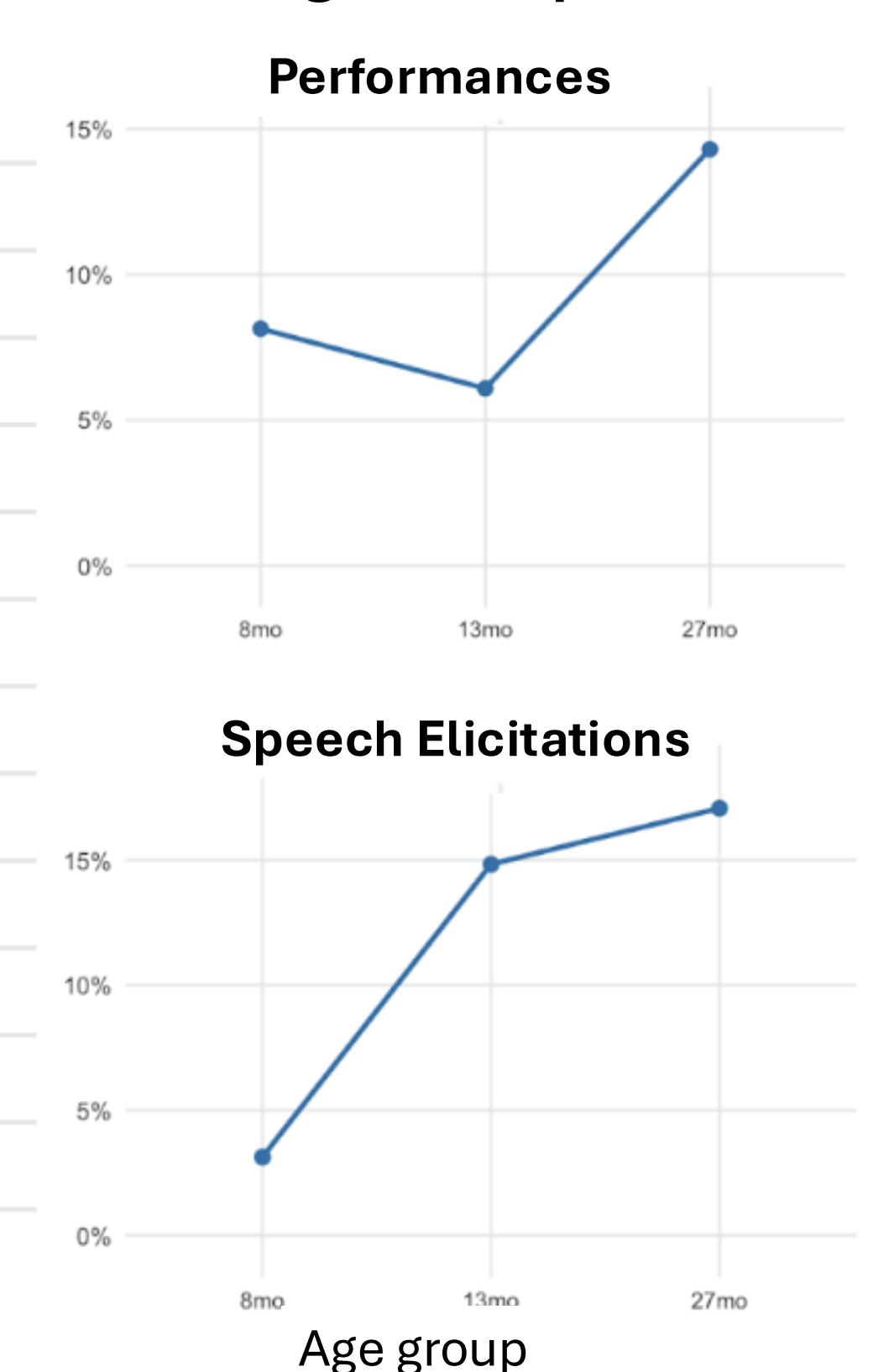
Honorifics usage was not directly proportional to the overall frequency of speech act categories within age groups. ($\chi^2 = 60.6; 158.7; 177.6$ (0;8; 1;1; 2;3), $p < 0.001$ for all)

Behavioral socialization? Linguistic socialization!

Dist. of honorific utts across speech act categories



Prop. utts w. honorifics markings w/in speech act



Behavior management with Directives and Evaluations...

에이 아파요 이렇게 하-면 일-어나-세요 이제 조끼 벗-고
INTERJ hurt-HON thus-ADV do-if rise-up-HON now vest take.off-CONN
'Ouch, it hurts if (you) do it like this.' 'Please get up now and take off your vest.'

...but also modeling through Performances and Speech Elicitations...

똑똑 문 열-어 주-세요 안녕히 계세요 하-해
ONOM door open-CONN give-HON-REQ well stay-HON do-IMP
'Knock knock, please open the door.' 'Say, "Goodbye!"'

...and building familiarity with politeness constructs with Questions.

이거 뭐-예요 뭐 하-고 놀-고 싶-어요
this-thing what-COP-HON what do-CONN play-CONN want-HON
'What is this?' 'What do you want to do (play)?'

Honorifics in CDS thus serves to dynamically scaffold both behavioral and linguistic socialization.

Discussion

Honorifics in CDS is dynamic and didactic, not static. Building on behavioral socialization accounts of CDS honorifics, we've established its additional role in facilitating linguistic socialization through systematic analyses of speech acts associated with honorifics-marked utterances.

How this selective socialization influences children's own early productions of honorific forms and when this CDS-specific function of honorifics gives way to socialized, addressee-dependent honorifics usage remains to be uncovered.

References

- [1] Ahn, J. (2020). Honorifics and peer conflict in Korean children's language socialization. *Linguistics and Education*, 59, 100736.
- [2] Bae, E. Y., Song, G., & Jeong, S. (2024). Addressee honorifics as an interactional resource for socialization in Korean adult-child interaction. In M. S. Kim (Ed.), *Exploring Korean politeness across online and offline interactions* (pp. 55-75). Springer.
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- [4] Ko, E.-S., Jo, J., On, K.-W., & Zhang, B.-T. (2020). Introducing the Ko corpus of Korean mother-child interaction. *Frontiers in Psychology*.
- [5] Ninio, A., Snow, C. E., Pan, B. A., & Rollins, P. R. (1994). Classifying communicative acts in children's interactions. *Journal of Communication Disorders*, 27(2), 157-187.
- [6] Sohn, H. M. (1999). *The Korean language*. Cambridge University Press.

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Poster, data and scripts